

Let's turn to the last assumption that the free will defense requires: the assumption that free will is a great good.

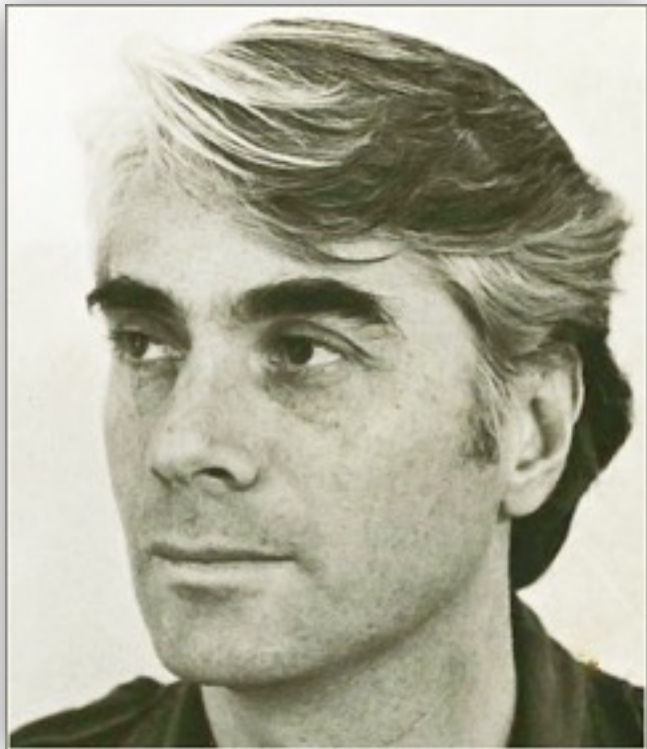
Free will is a
great good.

Even God could not
have given us free
will while ensuring
that we never used
that free will to
bring about evil.

We have free
will.

Many people think that it is; many think that life would not be worth living, or at least would be considerably worse, if we did not have free will.

The question we are raising is related to a famous thought experiment from the philosopher Robert Nozick.



“Suppose there were an experience machine that would give you any experience you desired. Superduper neuropsychologists could stimulate your brain so that you would think and feel you were writing a great novel, or making a friend, or reading an interesting book. All the time you would be floating in a tank, with electrodes attached to your brain ... Would you plug in? What else can matter to us, than how our lives feel from the inside?

Presumably the experience machine would also give you the illusion of free will. You would have the feeling that you were making decisions, and accomplishing things on your own. (Of course, while you were in the experience machine you would not know that you were in the experience machine — that would ruin the illusion.)

If given the choice, would you plug in? (You needn't worry about your friends and family — they would have the opportunity to plug into their own machines.)

Nozick thought that, on consideration, people would choose

not to plug in:

“We learn that something matters to us in addition to experience by imagining an experience machine and then realizing we would not use it. ... Perhaps what we desire is to live ourselves, in contact with reality. (And this, machines cannot do for us.)”



replies to
Libet

A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the Libet experiments" is written in a white, lowercase, sans-serif font, centered horizontally and vertically.

the Libet
experiments



is free will
an important
good?

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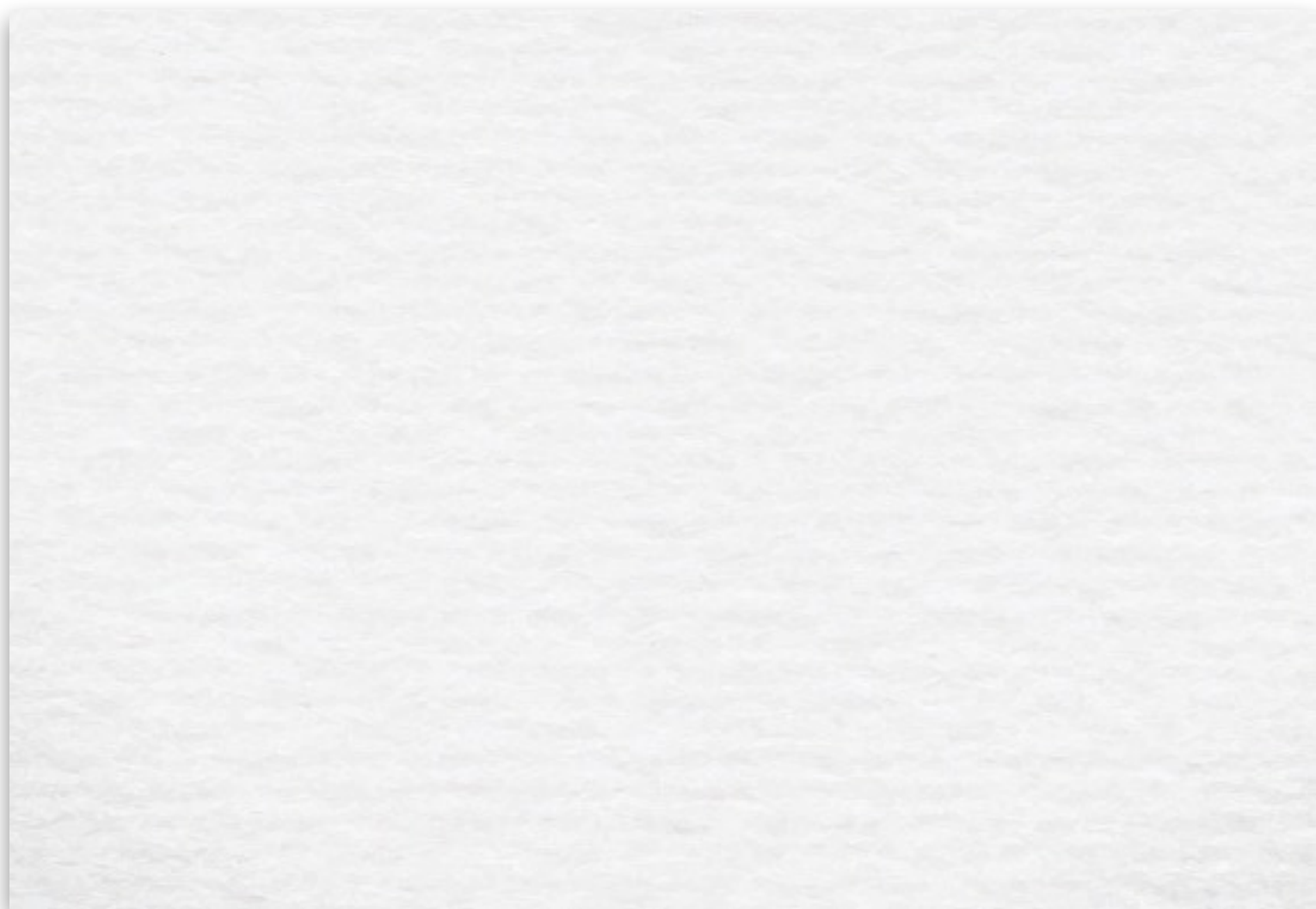
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never proposed to give up his coat of arms

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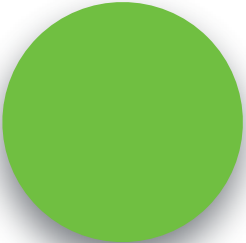
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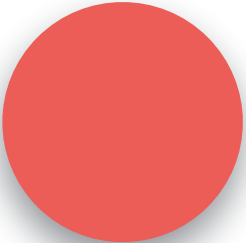


will prosper by contemporary neuroscience.

the birth of modern physics, many worried about the challenges it would bring from

In ancient times, philosophers worried about the challenge to free will from fate. After

determinism. Our topic today is much more recent challenge: the challenge to free





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